



GREY BANNER ALERT



mainroads
WESTERN AUSTRALIA

SHW Serious Incident (SI) – Final Notice

Date of Incident	17 th March 2026	Time of Incident	8:00 AM
Directorate / Region	RMO – Kimberley	Main Roads or Contractor	Contractor
EQSafe Event Type	Injury / Illness	EQSafe Incident Number	57466
Actual Consequence	Moderate	Potential Consequence	Major

Incident Short Description	Culvert crew worker bitten by snake
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Executive Summary

On Tuesday 17th March at approximately 7:45 AM, a contracted culvert crew had commenced works on site when they observed a snake in the work area. At approximately 8:00 AM, the supervisor observed a second snake in the area which was estimated to be 50-60cm in length and brown in colour.

The crew were instructed to stop work and allow the snake to move away from the area. After 10 minutes, the snake disappeared under some stone pitching further away from the work area. At this point, the supervisor instructed the crew to recommence works with a designated snake spotter in place.

As the crew were preparing to return to work, one of the workers (Injured Person – IP) informed the supervisor that he was feeling unwell and indicated that he believed he may have been bitten by a snake. The supervisor transported the IP back to camp, where he was checked for any signs of a snake bite. Puncture marks could not be located on the IP's leg; however, a compression bandage was applied as a precaution.

The supervisor then contacted the Halls Creek Hospital to advise that they were enroute with a suspected snake bite. After assessment of the IP's lower limbs, the Doctor advised that the IP was not showing any symptoms of a venomous bite, but that the IP would need to be transported via RFDS to Broome Hospital for further tests.

The IP remained at Broome Hospital overnight, where a doctor confirmed that he had been bitten by a suspected King Brown, however it was a 'dry' bite. The IP was released on Wednesday 18th March and was driven back to Halls Creek on Thursday 19th where he then returned to his home.

Contributing Factors

- Only a visual check of the work area was completed to check that snakes had left the area. A dynamic risk assessment consisting of a visual inspection (including checking under equipment,

and looking for movement tracks, shed skins and disturbed vegetation) and the identification of high-risk zones such as pallets, pipes, scrap rubble should always be completed.

- Work recommenced too soon based on the assumption that the snake had moved away, rather than confirm the area was safe.
- Culvert and rock work areas naturally harbour snakes, especially in hot weather conditions.
- Even with a snake spotter, the risk remained significant as snakes can be small, fast and difficult to detect.
- Ground crews do not always wear Gaters.
- The compression bandage was not applied immediately at the work site and was only applied once the worker had been transported to camp.
- Anti-venom is stored at only major hospitals across Western Australia due to its high cost. As a result, snake bite victims require transport via RFDS to the nearest equipped facility, which may delay administration of anti-venom and increase serious illness or fatality risk.

Corrective Actions

- Conduct refresher training for all Supervisors and key personnel on correct snake bite first aid, including pressure immobilisation, full limb bandaging, and the sequence of care in remote locations.
- Develop a clear, step-by-step snake bite response practice to include stop work requirements, roles of snake spotters and the first aid/emergency response procedure if a snake bite is suspected.
- Draft a snake bite emergency drill to be conducted at all depots, offices and project sites.
- Develop a standard protocol for workers who may be transported off-site to medical facilities which covers the provision of clean clothing and toiletries, and support for workers who are alone without family, the communication of incidents to next of kin.
- Install "Warning: Snakes in Area" signs at depots, camp, project off and site crib rooms.

Distribution of Notice

Main Roads Personnel and Contracting Organisations